

Asafoetida (*Ferula assa-foetida*, p. 210) helps to strengthen the gastrointestinal tract. It is often taken to treat indigestion.

Lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82). Lemon helps stave off colds by improving resistance to infection. It is thought to be native to India.

Dried lemon

Cardamom (*Elettaria cardamomum*, p. 93) has been used in India for thousands of years as a digestive remedy.

Fresh cardamom leaves

Cardamom seed

Cinnamon (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81) is a tonic herb taken to stimulate circulation.

Cinnamon sticks

Cinnamon powder

Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*, p. 152) has been called "Indian ginseng," and, much like ginseng, it is used to restore vitality and treat nervous exhaustion.

Jequirity (*Abrus precatorius*, p. 158). The seeds have been used in Asia as a contraceptive and abortifacient.

Soy (*Glycine max*, p. 217) is a highly nutritious bean that has become a staple crop around the world. The beans benefit the circulatory system.

Soybeans

Soybean pods

temperament, and susceptibility to illnesses are largely governed by the predominant *dosha*. In this way we inherit our basic constitution, called the *prakruti*, which remains unaltered throughout our lives.

The first requirement for health in Ayurveda is a proper balance of the *doshas*. If the balance is upset, illness, *ryadhi*, results. The disruption may be manifested in physical discomfort and pain, or in mental and emotional suffering, including jealousy, anger, fear, and sorrow. While our balance of *doshas* influences vulnerability to certain kinds of illness, the principles do not work in a vacuum.

The effect our lifestyle has on our *prakruti*—*vakruti*—has a strong effect on overall health, and it may easily disrupt *dosha* balance.

Illness may also result if the flow of energy, *prana*, around the body is interrupted. The flow is relayed via the seven *chakras* (psychic energy centers), which are situated at various points along the spinal column, from the crown of the head to the tailbone. If the energy flowing between these centers is blocked, the likelihood of ill health increases.

Visiting an Ayurvedic Practitioner

An Ayurvedic practitioner first carefully assesses *prakruti* and *vakruti*—constitution and lifestyle. This involves taking a detailed case history and carefully examining the body, paying attention to the build, the lines in the face and hands, and skin and hair type—all of which point to more profound aspects of the patient's condition. However, the main foundations on which diagnosis rests are the appearance of the tongue, and the pulse rate. In these respects, Ayurveda has much in common with Chinese and Tibetan medicine, in which these two indicators are also of the greatest importance. A very complex technique for taking the patient's pulse has been developed by Ayurvedic practitioners, requiring many years' experience.

When a *dosha* imbalance has been diagnosed, medical treatment and lifestyle advice are provided. The first step is eliminating toxins, and the main cleansing and rejuvenation program, known as *panchakarma*, includes therapeutic vomiting, purging, enemas, nasal administration of medication, and purification of the blood.

Attributes of Remedies

Subsequent treatments fall into three main categories: medicines from natural sources, dietary regimens, and behavioral modifications. Medicines, foods, and lifestyle activities are all classified according to their effect on the three *doshas*. For instance, a health problem associated with an excess of *kapha*, the water principle, is characterized by congestion, excess weight, fluid retention, and lethargy. The practitioner would prescribe the consumption of warm, dry, light foods, because the quality of *kapha* is cool and damp. Avoidance of cold damp foods (such as wheat, sugar, and milk products), which increase *kapha*, would also be advised. Herbal remedies would include warming spices such as ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155) and cayenne (*Capsicum frutescens*, p. 74), as well as bitters such as turmeric (*Curcuma longa*, p. 90).

The specific choice of herbal remedy depends on its "quality" or "energy," which Ayurveda determines according to twenty attributes (*vimshati guna*) such as hot, cold, wet, dry, heavy, or light. Ayurveda also classifies remedies according to six tastes—sweet, sour, salty, bitter, pungent, and astringent. Sweet, sour, and salty substances increase water